

Enterprise / Mayflower – prefab vs site-built comparison memo

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Executive take

I like the **condo / site-condo legal framing** here too.

It pairs well with a small coordinated cottage community because it lets you:

- keep the **shared drive / open-space / utility logic** together,
- preserve control over the overall look of the project,
- potentially sell or finance units without forcing a messy fee-simple lot pattern,
- handle the creek / sewer corridor as a true common element.

On the **building product** side, my current recommendation is:

1. **Best near-term path:** simple **site-built cottage** or a **conventional code-compliant modular/panelized permanent cottage**
2. **Best “cool factor” / marketing path:** the **Unfold-style prefab**
3. **Big caution:** Unfold has the most interesting product story, but it also has the **highest approval / certification / service-chain risk** for this Enterprise project

So if the goal is **get the deal entitled and buildable**, I would not make Unfold the only plan.

I would keep it as either:

- a **possible premium product option**, or
- a **pilot / model-unit idea**,

while underwriting the project around a more standard permanent-cottage delivery method.

The three product paths

Option A – Unfold-style foldable prefab

What it appears to be

From Unfold's public site:

- about **482 sf**
- folds to fit in a **40-foot shipping container**
- claims **on-site unfolding in under 3 hours** with about **a week of touch-up**
- public site says buyer is responsible for confirming local eligibility
- public site says manufacturing is being established in **China**

Option B – conventional permanent modular / panelized prefab

What I mean by this

A more standard off-site product, such as:

- domestic modular cottage,
- panelized cottage shell,
- factory-built permanent structure assembled on-site,

with a more typical U.S. code / inspection / installer pathway.

Option C – simple site-built cottage

What I mean by this

A small permanent cottage built on-site with conventional framing and local trades.

Best fit with your condo / site-condo idea

Condo structure works with all three – if the units are permanent buildings
That is the key.

For Enterprise, the safer framing is still:

- **permanent dwelling units**
- on **permanent foundations**
- in a coordinated development
- with shared common elements handled by the condo/site-condo regime

That legal structure can work whether the unit is:

- site-built,
- modular,
- or prefab,

as long as the City and building officials treat it as a permanent code-compliant dwelling.

Where the real difference shows up
The biggest difference is not legal theory.

It is:

- **permitting certainty**
- **state modular approval**,
- **inspection path**,
- **installer availability**,
- **warranty/service after delivery**.

That is why Option A is the most exciting visually, but also the riskiest operationally.

Comparison by issue

1) Entitlement / zoning fit for Enterprise

Option A – Unfold

Medium fit in concept, weaker fit in practice right now

Why:

- If treated as a permanent cottage on foundation, it may conceptually fit the development story.
- But Enterprise will likely care less about the "folding" idea and more about whether it is a **recognized permanent dwelling product** that cleanly fits their code and permit process.
- Because Unfold's own site puts local eligibility on the buyer, this creates friction at the exact point where we want clarity.

Option B – conventional modular/panelized

Strong fit

Why:

- Easier to present as a normal permanent dwelling product.
- Easier to defend in a planning conversation.
- Lower chance that staff gets distracted by the novelty of the system.

Option C – site-built cottage

Strongest fit

Why:

- Simplest explanation.
- Simplest code story.

- Least likely to trigger avoidable skepticism from City staff.

2) Alabama code / approval risk

Option A – Unfold **Highest risk**

Important points from the sources reviewed:

- Alabama requires modular/manufactured building installation to be done by a **certified installer** through the Alabama Manufactured Housing Commission.
- Public Alabama modular materials indicate state **insignia / compliance** matters, especially for out-of-state units.
- Unfold's own website says the **buyer is responsible** for determining local eligibility and that Unfold will provide technical documentation and support.
- Unfold also states manufacturing is being established in **China**.

That combination worries me a bit for this project.

Not because it cannot work – it might – but because there are more places for delay:

- state acceptance of the product,
- engineering review,
- installer path,
- local building official comfort,
- replacement parts / service / warranty follow-through.

Option B – conventional modular/panelized **Moderate risk**

Still needs:

- proper state/local compliance,
- foundation engineering,
- installer coordination,
- utility connection and inspections,

but the path is much more normal.

Option C – site-built cottage **Lowest risk**

Still has ordinary permit and inspection risk, but much less product-certification uncertainty.

3) Speed to build

Option A – Unfold **Potentially fastest on-site assembly**

This is the sexy part.

If the product is approved and logistics are smooth, site assembly could be very fast.

But total project speed is not just unfolding time.

It also includes:

- approvals,
- ordering lead time,
- shipping,
- customs/import risk,
- damage risk in transit,
- installer scheduling,
- finish punch list,
- local inspections.

So the house may unfold in hours while the project still moves slower overall.

Option B – conventional modular/panelized

****Usually fast enough****

Good middle ground:

- faster than full site build,
- less exotic than Unfold,
- more bankable operationally.

Option C – site-built cottage

****Slowest field production****

Especially if repeated across many units with standard local crews.

But it may still be the fastest path to a first approved phase because it avoids product-approval friction.

4) Cost certainty

Option A – Unfold

****Hardest to trust early****

The public site clearly notes extra costs for:

- permitting,
- taxes,
- transport,
- installation,

after site survey.

That is normal, but here it matters more because international shipping and state acceptance add uncertainty.

Option B – conventional modular/panelized

****Better cost control****

Factory pricing can help. Freight and installation are still meaningful, but usually easier to model.

Option C – site-built cottage

****Most familiar but subject to labor creep****

You know the moving parts better, but field labor and schedule drift can eat the budget.

5) Ability to self-perform / "put together ourselves"

Option A – Unfold

****This is where I'd be careful****

I get why it is appealing.

But Alabama modular installation rules make me cautious about assuming true DIY assembly if the unit is treated as a modular/manufactured building product.

Even if you can do a lot of work around it, I would assume:

- certified installer involvement,
- engineered foundation requirements,
- formal inspection sequence,
- more restricted scope for what the ownership team can personally do.

Option B – conventional modular/panelized

****Moderate self-perform potential****

Depends on the system.

Some panelized or shell-first products give more room for your team to finish out parts of the work.

Option C – site-built cottage **Best self-perform flexibility**

If you want to control more of the build process yourself, this is usually the cleanest lane.

6) Aesthetics / marketability

Option A – Unfold **Highest wow factor**

Honestly, this is where Unfold wins.

It looks sharp, contemporary, memorable.

That matters if the project is targeting:

- young professionals,
- aviation / training / workforce renters wanting something distinct,
- social-media-friendly marketing,
- premium small-footprint resale appeal.

Option B – conventional modular/panelized **Can still look very good**

This depends on design discipline. You can absolutely make this feel premium. But it takes better elevation/exterior choices.

Option C – site-built cottage **Most flexible aesthetically**

This gives you the most design freedom.

If the project brand matters a lot, this may actually be the best long-term answer.

7) Maintenance / replacement / service

Option A – Unfold **Highest long-tail risk**

Questions I would want answered before trusting it at scale:

- Who services warranty claims in Alabama?
- Who handles damaged panels, windows, hardware, or folding components?
- What replacement parts are domestic vs imported?
- What happens if the company pivots or disappears?
- Who certifies repairs if the folding structure is modified or damaged?

Option B – conventional modular/panelized **Better serviceability**

Usually easier to source support, parts, and trades.

Option C – site-built cottage **Best serviceability**

Any competent local contractor can usually work on it later.

My recommendation for this specific project

Best primary path

For the Enterprise / Mayflower tract, I would base the project on:

either

****Option B – conventional permanent modular/panelized cottages****

or

****Option C – simple site-built cottages****

Those two are the best mix of:

- entitlement credibility,
- code clarity,
- condo/site-condo compatibility,
- lender/appraiser comfort,
- serviceability.

How I would use Unfold if you love it

I would not throw it out.

I'd just use it more strategically.

Smart ways to use Unfold

1. ****Pilot unit / showcase model****

- one standout unit to test demand and process

2. ****Design benchmark****

- use its look/feel as inspiration for a simpler permanent cottage product

3. ****Phase-two option****

- only after City, installer, certification, and warranty paths are confirmed

What I would not do yet

I would ****not**** underwrite the whole project around Unfold today without answers on:

- Alabama approval path
- installer path
- engineering package
- local code acceptance in Enterprise
- warranty / service structure
- landed installed cost

Practical ranking

Best for lowest risk

1. ****Site-built cottage****

2. ****Conventional modular/panelized permanent cottage****

3. ****Unfold****

Best for speed if approvals are clean

1. ****Conventional modular/panelized****

2. ****Unfold****

3. ****Site-built****

Best for visual differentiation / marketing

1. ****Unfold****

2. ****Well-designed site-built cottage****

3. ****Conventional modular/panelized****

Best for a first phase that actually gets permitted and built

1. ****Site-built or conventional modular/panelized****

2. ****Unfold later if it survives due diligence****

My blunt recommendation
If this were my call, I'd do this:

Development strategy

- Keep the **condo/site-condo** legal structure.
- Sell the project as a **permanent cottage community**, not a tiny-home gimmick
- Underwrite the initial plan around **18 units**.

Product strategy

- Use **site-built** or standard modular/panelized permanent cottages as the base product.
- Use **Unfold** as inspiration or a pilot, not as the only build strategy yet.

That gives you:

- the strongest path with the City,
- the cleanest long-term asset,
- less code drama,
- more lender/appraiser comfort,
- and still leaves room for a sharp, modern look.

Best next steps if you want me to keep pushing

1. Build a **due-diligence checklist** specifically for using Unfold in Alabama / Enterprise
2. Build a **product-criteria sheet** for the ideal Mayflower cottage unit
3. Draft a **one-page concept brief** framing the project as a condo/site-condo permanent cottage community
4. Compare likely **unit mixes** around 482 sf, ~600 sf, and ~750 sf products for parking + yield

Sources used for this memo

- <https://unfoldhouse.com/>
- <https://unfoldhouse.com/how-it-works/>
- <https://unfoldhouse.com/for-developer/>
- <https://unfoldhouse.com/our-story/>
- <https://amhc.alabama.gov/installers.aspx>
- Enterprise zoning/parking/development-plan sources already gathered in the project folder